

NSDR Protocol Guide

Three structured non-sleep deep rest protocols for stress recovery, faster learning consolidation, and mental restoration without a nap.

Evidence-based approach: yoga nidra dopamine research (Kjaer et al., 2002) and iRest cortisol / mood studies (Markil et al., 2012).

How To Use This Guide

NSDR (non-sleep deep rest) is a term popularized by neuroscientist Andrew Huberman to describe structured relaxation protocols derived from yoga nidra that lower cortisol and heart rate without requiring sleep. Pick the protocol length that fits your day: 10 minutes for a midday reset, 20 minutes for deeper recovery after a hard training session or a stressful stretch of work. Lie down, read the script once beforehand so you're not checking the page mid-practice, then close your eyes and move through it slowly.

What NSDR Actually Is

1. A guided practice of stillness, breath awareness, and body scanning performed lying down with eyes closed.
2. Distinct from meditation in that there is no concentration effort — attention is passively guided, not held.
3. Rooted in yoga nidra, studied in a 2002 NeuroImage paper by Kjaer et al. that recorded a 65% increase in striatal dopamine release during the practice.
4. Shown to reduce cortisol and improve mood in a 2012 Journal of Alternative and Complementary Medicine study of the iRest protocol in veterans by Markil and colleagues.
5. Does not replace sleep, but can meaningfully reduce sleep debt's short-term impact on alertness and mood.

Protocol 1 — 10-Minute Reset

Best for a midday energy dip or a short reset between focused work blocks.

1. Lie down or recline somewhere you won't be disturbed. Let your arms rest at your sides, palms up.
2. Take three slow breaths, exhaling longer than you inhale, then let your breathing return to normal.
3. Scan attention slowly from your feet to your scalp, noticing sensation in each area without changing anything.
4. Bring attention to the weight of your body against the surface beneath you for 60 seconds.
5. Silently note the sounds in the room, from nearest to farthest, without labeling them as good or bad.
6. Return attention to your breath for the final two minutes, counting each exhale up to ten, then restarting.
7. Open your eyes, wiggle your fingers and toes, and sit up slowly before standing.

Protocol 2 — 20-Minute Deep Recovery

Best after a demanding training session, a stressful day, or when sleep the night before was short.

1. Lie flat, arms and legs slightly apart, and set an intention for the practice — rest, recovery, or simply presence.
2. Spend two minutes on slow, extended exhale breathing to downshift the nervous system before beginning.
3. Move through a full body scan, pausing 5-8 seconds on each region: feet, calves, thighs, hips, abdomen, chest, hands, arms, shoulders, neck, face.
4. Notice any areas of tension without trying to release them — awareness alone is the practice, not relaxation effort.
5. Spend three to five minutes resting in stillness with no directed task, letting attention drift.
6. Gently return awareness to the breath and the room around you for the final two minutes.
7. Transition slowly: small movements first, then sitting up, before resuming activity.

When To Use NSDR

1. Between deep work sessions to consolidate what was just learned or practiced.
2. Post-workout, in place of or alongside a cool-down, to lower elevated cortisol faster.
3. Mid-afternoon, as an alternative to caffeine when a full nap isn't practical.
4. Before a high-stakes conversation or presentation, to downshift pre-event activation.